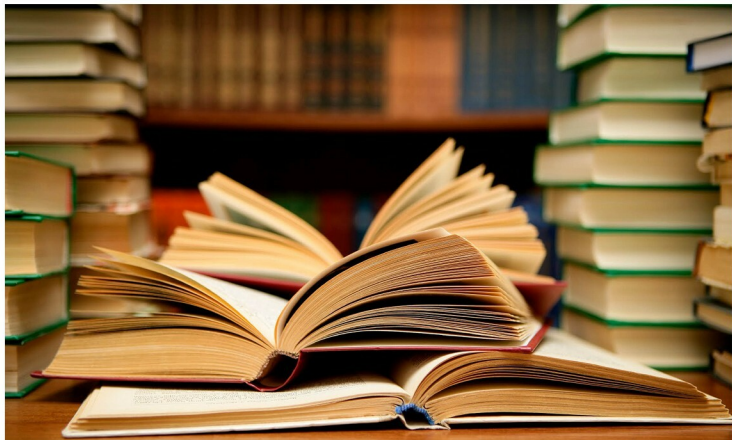


Top FOSS Tools that Assist Scholarly Research

Free and open source software has a lot to offer research scholars and higher education students in carrying out their academic activities in an efficient manner. These tools assist in surveying the literature, managing references, drafting manuscripts and theses, making presentations, building graphical illustrations and in collaborating with peers.



Scholarly research is a dynamic and complex activity. It incorporates various components that require high levels of cognitive skills. Similar to other aspects of life, the research domain has also benefited a lot from IT tools. Any one associated with academic research is well aware that usually, only a limited budget is allotted to IT tools. In such a scenario, getting commercial and proprietary IT tools is difficult from both the financial and procedural perspectives. Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) performing research tasks has been a big boon for academic researchers. Let me make it clear that the FOSS tools featured in this article have not been selected only because of near-zero costs, but also for their professional features which are on par with their commercial counterparts, if not better.

This article attempts to highlight FOSS tools associated with various aspects of academic research, which are listed below:

- Searching the literature and reference management

- Drafting a manuscript
- Building graphical illustrations
- Networking and collaboration
- Analysis tools

For each one of the above mentioned requirements, there are umpteen FOSS tools. Exploring each of these tools is not feasible due to space limitations. Hence, this article introduces one or two leading tools for each requirement.

Searching the literature and reference management

One important task that's repeatedly carried out by scholars is collecting information from existing literature. 'Search – search again and re-search' constitutes the major chunk of the work in academic research. By the term 'searching' I don't only refer to the simple task of searching in a search engine as carried out by regular users. Here, 'search' implies the task of collecting information from various sources. Of course,